✦ STEP 4 · AFFIRMATIVE

The case for recognition

Two strong contentions that are hard to attack, plus backup reasons. Each one has the attack to expect and an answer ready.

💡 **FORMAT FOR EVERY ARGUMENT**

Claim (what you're saying) → **Proof** (a fact or evidence) → **So what** (why the U.S. should care).

✧ Contention 1: Somaliland already IS a country STRONGEST

Claim: Recognition just admits what's already true.

Proof: The **Montevideo Convention (1933)**, which the **U.S. signed**, lists four things that make a country a country:

1. People who live there permanently ✅
2. Territory it controls ✅
3. A government ✅
4. The ability to deal with other countries ✅

Somaliland has had all four for **over 30 years**. The treaty also says a country's existence **doesn't depend** on other countries recognizing it. And Somaliland is a **democracy**: in November 2024 the opposition won, and the sitting president stepped down peacefully.

So what: The U.S. is refusing to admit what its own treaty says. Not recognizing a peaceful democracy tells the world that being democratic gets you nothing, which removes the **incentive** to be democratic.

Attack to expect

NEG "In 2023 it lost Las Anod, and those people joined Somalia. So Somaliland doesn't control its territory, *right?*"

YOU "**No.** Somaliland still controls most of its land, including its capital and its main port. And recognized countries have border disputes too: India and Pakistan both claim Kashmir, and both are recognized. That isn't a reason to deny recognition."

NEG "The U.S. recognizes lots of countries that aren't democracies. Why should democracy matter?"

YOU "Democracy isn't the only reason. It's one good reason among several. Somaliland also meets every part of the Montevideo test and sits in a key location."

⚠ **DON'T OVERCLAIM**

Don't say "almost all U.S. allies are democracies." Saudi Arabia, the UAE and Egypt are close partners and aren't. Say "many of America's closest allies, like the UK and Japan, are democracies."

✧ Contention 2: Somaliland's case is unique STRONG

Claim: Recognizing Somaliland wouldn't set an example for other regions to break away.

Proof:

- **Old wall, not a new wall.** Picture two houses that knocked down the wall between them in 1960. Somaliland wants to put the wall back **exactly where it was**. Most breakaway regions were always part of one house and want to build a **brand-new** wall.
- **Even the African Union agreed.** Its own 2005 fact-finding mission called Somaliland's case "historically unique and self-justified." VERIFY
- **It's happened before. Eritrea** (1993) and **South Sudan** (2011) became countries, and Africa did not break apart.

So what: This knocks out the Neg's breakaway argument before they even make it. Other regions couldn't use Somaliland as an excuse.

💡 **WHY THE AU POINT IS SO STRONG**

The AU **opposes** recognition today. When your **opponent's own side** admits something, the judge believes it. Say: "**Even the African Union**, which opposes recognition, admitted in 2005 that Somaliland's case is unique."

Attack to expect

NEG "The AU today says recognition is a dangerous precedent."

YOU "The AU's own investigators said the opposite. It just never acted on their report."

NEG "Somaliland chose to join Somalia in 1960. Nobody forced it."

YOU "The union was never properly ratified, and northerners voted against the 1961 constitution. And choosing to join doesn't mean accepting being bombed by your own government. Somalia broke the deal, not Somaliland."

✧ Backup reasons

These are good, but easier to attack. Use them as extra support, not as main contentions.

📍 Location, shipping and China

Somaliland sits near the Red Sea shipping route, where the Houthis have attacked ships. Its president has **offered** the U.S. access to the port of **Berbera**. China already has a base next door in Djibouti, about 4 miles from the main U.S. base. Recognizing Somaliland could give the U.S. a **backup partner** in the region. (Your Aff evidence card supports this.)

Weak spot: the Neg will say "we can work with Berbera without recognizing Somaliland." Answer: a real long-term base deal is much easier with a recognized government.

Word choice: say "presence" or "influence," not "dominance." And don't say "we get the ports," because recognition doesn't hand them over.

🇹🇼 Taiwan

In **2020**, Somaliland chose Taiwan over China, even when China pressured it. The U.S. and Somaliland share a goal: **limiting China's influence**. Partners who take risks for U.S. friends deserve support.

Weak spot: "The U.S. doesn't recognize Taiwan either!" Answer: "True, but the U.S. still supports Taiwan strongly. Somaliland took a real risk to stand with a U.S. friend."

🕊️ Democracy (as part of Contention 1)

Somaliland has held several elections. In 2003 the presidential race was decided by about 80 votes, and the dispute went to court instead of to war. In 2024 the opposition won, and the president stepped down. In that region, leaders losing and actually leaving is rare.

✧ Answers to the Neg's best arguments

Neg says	You answer
"We already get the benefits without recognition."	"Without recognition, there are no real embassies, no official treaties, no long-term base agreements. Unofficial ties can be dropped at any time, and China and Turkey are moving faster."
"We'd lose Somalia's help against al-Shabaab."	"Somalia needs U.S. help against al-Shabaab more than the U.S. needs Somalia. It's fighting for its own survival. And the U.S. relationship with Somalia has already changed: most aid was cut and Somali nationals are barred from entering the U.S."
"Our allies would be angry."	"The U.S. recognized **Kosovo** in 2008 even though Serbia and Russia were furious, and it worked out. Someone has to go first, and Israel already did."
"Other regions will break away."	Use Contention 2: unique case, the AU 2005 mission, Eritrea and South Sudan.

🔍 **BEFORE YOU QUOTE**

Check the AU 2005 quote and any death toll for 1988 against a source you can open. See the verify list.